

PATIENT HUNTER

The giant grouper usually lurks close to the sea bottom, often lying among coral or rocks, until an unwary crustacean or slow-moving fish swims close by. Capture follows a quick lunge and opening of the cavernous mouth to suck in the prey. Numerous, depressible, needlelike teeth secure the quarry in the mouth.

*Epinephelus lanceolatus***Giant grouper**

Location Indian Ocean, W. and C. Pacific

Length Up to 8¼ ft (2.5 m)

Weight Up to 880 lb (400 kg)

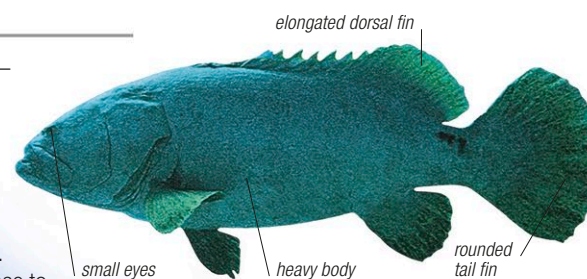
Sex Sequential hermaphrodite

Status Vulnerable



A dark behemoth of a fish—one of the largest of the groupers—the giant grouper lives in warm, shallow, coastal waters; it may also be seen in estuaries, able to survive in the brackish conditions. Usually solitary, it stays close to coral and rocky reefs, remaining largely in the same area, usually around caves and wrecks. The giant grouper feeds mainly on crustaceans, with a favorite food being the spiny lobster, but it is also known to eat crabs, a variety of fishes such as small sharks and rays, and young sea turtles. As juveniles, they are preyed upon by other fishes, but as mature adults, they are typically at risk only from humans. Their often massive size and fairly sluggish behavior has made them an easy target of spearfishing. Since their great size

requires a large food source and takes many years to develop, their density on reefs is extremely limited. They are easily fished out of entire regions, with little chance of their reappearance unless they are strictly protected. The giant grouper's close relation, the jewfish or Goliath grouper (*Epinephelus itajara*), is now so scarce that, in US waters at least, it is protected, with all harvesting of it prohibited.

**ROBUST BUILD**

Also known as the Queensland grouper, this fish has a characteristically heavy body and large mouth. Its typical coloration is brownish, with light mottling.

**NOT-SO-GENTLE GIANT**

The giant grouper is usually easily approached by divers—but some larger specimens are believed to have attacked and killed humans.